How to Use Meal Order to Reduce Blood Sugar Spikes

Home Screen

Same food, healthier life.

This lesson explains how the food ordering affects your glucose levels, why that's important and teaches one habit: start with vegetables/fiber, then protein, and save the starchier carbs for last.

Start Lesson

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Why care about this topic?

Why care about blood sugar spikes?

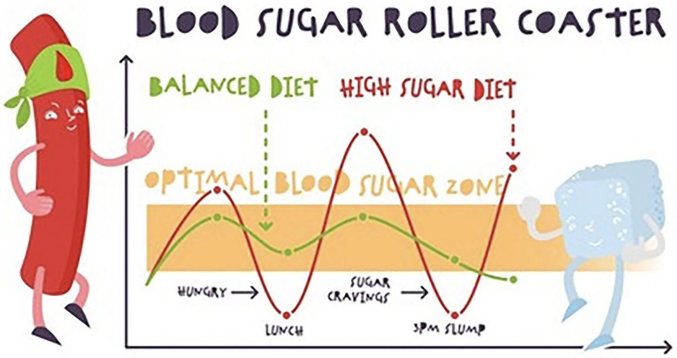
Short-term impact:

- Hunger soon after eating
- Energy crashes

Long-term impact:

- Increased risk of Type 2 Diabetes
- Fat storage and weight gain

Goal: keep glucose stable, not spiking



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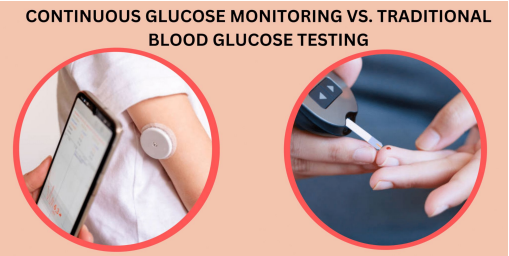
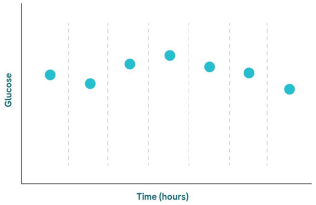
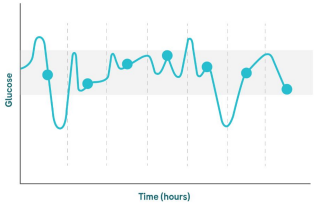
How to track blood sugar?

Track blood glucose over time to understand what affects it

- Two methods:
  - BGM (blood glucose monitor): finger-prick, single reading at one moment
  - CGM (continuous glucose monitor): wearable sensor, tracks glucose continuously (24/7)







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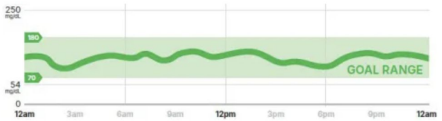
How to Interpret Your Readings

How to Interpret Your Readings

- Typical target range: 70–180 mg/dL (milligrams per deciliter)
- Goal: keep glucose within this range
- Watch for:
  - Spikes (going up)
  - Drops (going down)
- If levels go outside the range:
  - Think about what caused it (e.g., food, meal order)
- Key idea: use patterns to make better decisions next time



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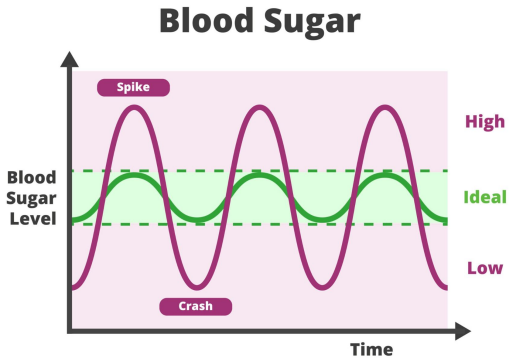
What influences blood sugar?

What can make your blood glucose level go up?

- Too much food
- Not enough physical activity.
- Not taking enough insulin or other diabetes medications.
- Side effects from other medications, like steroids.
- Not staying hydrated.

Other factors including:

- Getting sick
- Stress
- Pain
- Menstrual cycle (this can also lead to lows)



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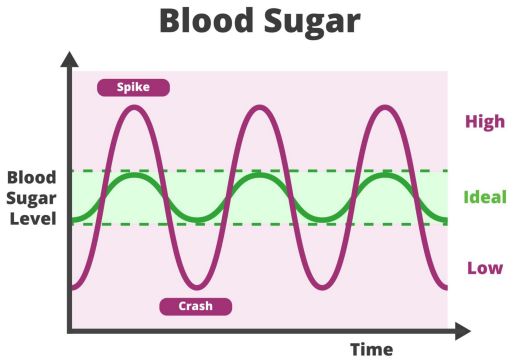
What influences blood sugar?

What can make your blood glucose level go down?

- Too little food and missing meals or snacks.
- Side effects from other medications.
- Alcohol, especially on an empty stomach.
- Menstrual cycle (this can also lead to high blood glucose).
- More physical activity or exercise than usual.



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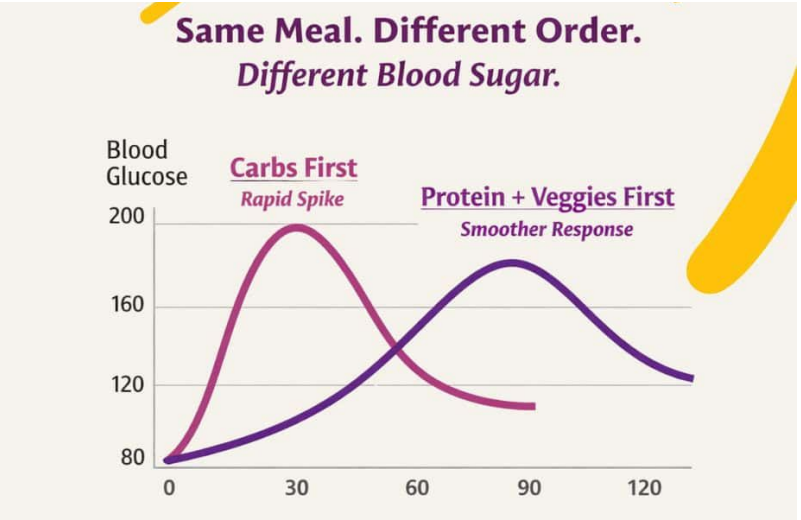
Explain the core concept

Why meal order matters

Some studies suggest that the order in which you eat foods during a meal can significantly affect blood sugar spikes, even if the total meal stays the same.

In one small study of people with type 2 diabetes, participants ate the same meal twice but in different orders (carbs first vs. carbs last). Researchers found that eating protein and vegetables before carbohydrates led to much lower post-meal glucose levels.



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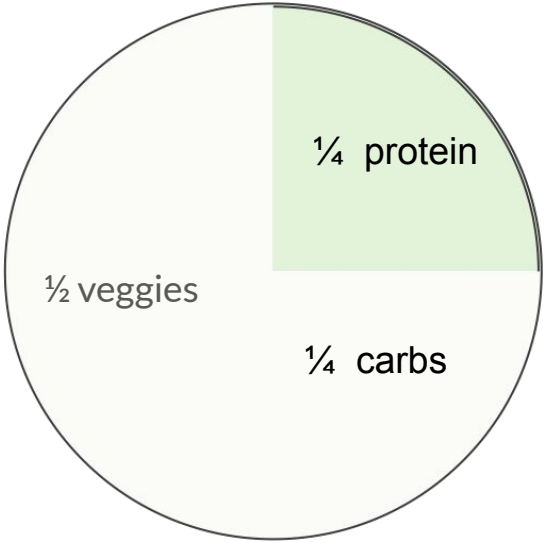
Show the best practice

Use the Diabetes Plate as the meal template

The Diabetes Plate is the easiest way to create healthy low-carb meals that can help you manage your blood glucose (blood sugar). This is how it works:

1. Fill 1/2 your plate with nonstarchy vegetables.
2. Fill 1/4 of your plate with lean protein foods
3. Fill 1/4 of your plate with carbohydrate foods



Teach the Core Lesson

One simple way to reduce blood sugar spikes is by changing the order you eat your food. The 3-step eating order is:

1. **Start with vegetables or other high-fiber parts**

   Examples: salad, broccoli, cucumbers, edamame, beans.

2. **Then eat the protein / fat part**

   Examples: chicken, fish, tofu, eggs, Greek yogurt, nuts.

3. **Finish with the starchier carbs**

   Examples: rice, bread, noodles, potatoes, dessert.

Edge cases

What if the meal is mixed together?

1 Shortcut 1

Start with the bites that are richest in vegetables or protein.

2 Shortcut 2

If there is a side salad or veggie side, eat that first.

3 Shortcut 3

You still get some benefit from slowing down instead of inhaling the carb-heavy part first.

QUIZ

Now let's test your knowledge!

Answer a series of questions to test your understanding of the material.

Start Quiz

Quiz

Practice on one meal: click the food in order that it should be eaten

Step 12 of 14

3

2

1

Quiz 1 of 3

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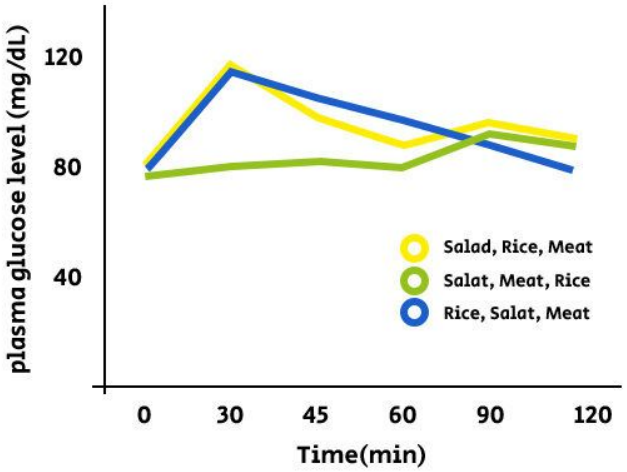
Practice Feedback:

Correct! Best answer: salad -> chicken -> rice

Reason: Look at the glucose chart to understand which meal order results in the lowest blood sugar spike: salad, meat, rice.



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Quiz

Which meal order is more likely to reduce the blood sugar spike?

A
Bread first
Turkey second
Side salad Last

B
Side salad first
Turkey second
Bread Last

Tap either answer to view feedback.

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Quiz feedback

Correct answer: B

B

Side salad first → turkey second → bread last

Reason: The bread still belongs in the meal. The lower-spike choice simply delays it until after the fiber and protein.

Quiz

Breakfast version: which order is more likely to reduce the spike?

A
Toast first
Eggs second
Berries Last

B
Berries first
Eggs second
Toast Last

Hint: look for protein before starch

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Quiz feedback

Correct answer: B

B

Berries first → eggs second → toast last

Reason: It follows the same logic: fruit/fiber first, protein next, bread last. This does not make a sweet breakfast “free”: it just points to the gentler order.

Wrap-up

Takeaway:

If the goal is to reduce the size of a post-meal glucose spike, the safer default is usually:

1. **1. Vegetables / fiber first**

   Salad, broccoli, cucumbers, beans, berries, edamame.

2. **2. Protein / fat next**

   Chicken, fish, eggs, tofu, yogurt, nuts.

3. **3. Carbs last**

   Rice, bread, noodles, potatoes, dessert.

Try it tonight

- ☐ Keep the meal the same
- ☐ Start with the vegetable/fiber part
- ☐ Eat the protein next
- ☐ Save the main starch for the end
- ☐ Notice whether the post-meal crash feels smaller

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